

Folk etymology and the diachronic survival of Latin loanwords in Greek

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Abstract

This article attempts to examine the linguistic phenomenon of folk etymology and to ascertain its contribution to the probable initial introduction and later survival of Latin loans in Standard Modern Greek. Specifically, it emerges that from a corpus of approximately 200 surviving Latin words, there is a recorded paretymological connection with Greek morphemes in a percentage of around 10% (c.a. 20 words). The linguistic data are drawn from the electronic corpus of TLG texts and mostly concern medieval dictionaries, such as the Etymologicum Magnum, the Suda Dictionary, etc. The possibility that this etymological association is not carried out by most speakers but constitutes a conscious practice of Byzantine scholars with normative - regulatory intentions, is underlined and its balancing is sought through the examination of texts of non-metalinguistic content, such as papyri, etc. In parallel with paretymology, the claim is made that the acoustic similarity between Greek and Latin words, due to a common Indo - European origin, also contributed to the introduction of the latter into the language through their grouping in the mental lexicon.

Keywords: *analogy, lexical borrowing, folk etymology, Latin loanwords, mental lexicon, Standard Modern Greek.*

1 Introduction¹

Folk etymology² or paretymology has long been discussed in the linguistic literature as

¹ Abbreviations: Dic. = Dictionary, e.g. = exempli gratia, Eng.= English, ex. = example, EAM = Ετυμολογικό Λεξικό Μπαμπινιώτη 'Babiniotis Etymological Dictionary', Fr. = French, Gr. = Greek, Hell.Gk. = Hellenistic Greek, IANE = Ιστορικό Λεξικό Νέας Ελληνικής 'Historical Dictionary of Modern Greek', I/E = Indo - European, It. = Italian, Kerk. = Kerkyraika (Corfu), Lat. = Latin, Λ.ΙΝΣ = Λεξικό Ινστιτούτου Νεοελληνικών Σπουδών 'Modern Greek Studies Dictionary', Med.Gk. = Medieval Greek, s. = see, SMGk.. = Standard Modern Greek, Turk. = Turkish, Ven. = Venetian.

² The term derives from the German *Volksetymologie*, a word coined in 1852 by Ernst Förstemann (Filos

a mechanism of reanalysis that enhances semantic and morphological transparency by associating opaque forms with more familiar lexical material (Michel 2015). Traditionally, it has often been approached either as a deviation from the established linguistic norm (Θεοδωροπούλου & Παπαναστασίου 2001)³ or as a cognitively motivated strategy employed by speakers in the process of language acquisition and lexical categorization (Μότσιου 2015). The second approach is related to psycholinguistic processes and cognitive functions, which appear both in adult and in child speech, and fall under the mechanism of analogy (McMahon 1994: 183–4).⁴

From a diachronic perspective, folk etymology constitutes a productive mechanism of lexical change, particularly in situations of language contact. Loanwords whose original structure becomes opaque over time are especially prone to reanalysis, as speakers attempt to integrate them into the receiving language by associating them with formally or semantically similar native elements (Anastasiadis – Simeonidis 2003). In this sense, folk etymology may contribute not only to formal reshaping, but also to the successful integration and long-term survival of borrowed lexical items.

Greek provides a particularly suitable testing ground for the diachronic study of folk etymology, due to its long-written tradition and its sustained contact with Latin in particular from the Hellenistic period through Late Antiquity and the Byzantine era. Numerous Latin loanwords entered Greek at different stages and were transmitted across centuries in written sources. Various strategies of reanalysis emerged, often reflected in alternative spellings, reinterpretations recorded by lexicographers, or associations with formally similar Greek words.

The present study examines the role of folk etymology in the diachronic transmission and survival of Latin loanwords from late Antiquity to Modern Greek. Drawing on data from the Thesaurus Linguae Graecae (TLG) and related documentary

2019). During the 19th century research on folk etymology is mainly focused on the analysis of single examples. Nevertheless, already in 1886 Behaghel's *Die deutsche Sprache* a more theoretical perspective is presented considering folk etymology a general phenomenon of language perception outside of the sociolinguistic frame the term 'folk' implies (Michel 2015).

³ Saussure reached to the point of perceiving folk etymology as a negative, "pathologic" process (de Saussure 1967: 210). Paretymology, nevertheless does not aim at the corruption of a lexical unit (see among others Palmer 1882), but at increasing the morphosemantic transparency.

⁴ Already Wilhelm Wundt at the beginning of the 20th century introduces the term "lautlich-begriffliche Wortassimilation" 'phonic and conceptual word assimilation' (Wundt 1900: 477) which, for him, is a purely associative process belonging to the psychophysical mechanism of language function (Michel 2015).

sources, it presents a set of attested cases in which Latin lexical items were reanalyzed through association with Greek morphemes or lexemes. These cases include both forms that underwent phonological or morphological reshaping and forms whose folk-etymological reinterpretation is primarily reflected at the level of semantic or orthographic analysis. While it cannot be proved that it was a decisive factor in the initial borrowing of Latin items (s. example 1 nevertheless), folk etymology appears to have played a non-negligible role in the retention and refunctionalization of some Latin words within the Greek lexicon.

By focusing on concrete, textually attested examples, this paper aims to demonstrate that folk etymology was not an isolated or marginal phenomenon, but a recurrent mechanism operating across different periods and textual genres. It is argued that, in combination with phonological similarity and shared Indo-European (I/E) lexical material, folk-etymological reanalysis facilitated the integration of certain Latin loans into the Greek lexicon and supported their diachronic continuity. The study thus bridges historical lexicology, language contact, and cognitive approaches to reanalysis, by grounding theoretical claims in a systematically documented corpus.

2 Theoretical overview

Folk etymology essentially constitutes a form of reanalysis of a word or phrase (Bauer 2006: 520) with the purpose of enhancing semantic transparency, i.e., a clearer perception of the morphological elements of which it consists of. Put more simply, the speakers, in attempting to bring an unfamiliar word (or phrase) into line with their own understanding, etymologize it “incorrectly,” adapting it to forms that are already known, so that the semantic construction becomes comprehensible to them (s. Michel 2015, Μωυσιάδης & Κατσούδα 2011). For example, the Greek word *αθυρόστομος* ‘foul-mouthed’ (< *άθυρος* ‘no door’ + *στόμα* ‘mouth’) is folk-etymologized as *ανθηρόστομος* (< *ανθηρός* ‘flourishing’ + *στόμα* ‘mouth’) because semantically the word *άθυρος* is no longer easily associated in the speaker’s linguistic intuition with the meaning “open,” whereas *ανθηρός* ‘flourishing’ seems a more “justified” choice as a constituent of the word (Θεοδωροπούλου & Παπαναστασίου 2001). This constitutes a case of folk etymology via morphological resegmentation, whereby *αθυρόστομος* was reanalysed as *ανθηρόστομος* under the influence of *ανθηρός*.

In this process, knowledge and linguistic tools are used that concern only the

synchronic level of the language, since the connection with another word has no diachronic/etymological basis but relies solely on acoustic similarity (McMahon 1994: 183). It should be noted that, in most cases, the meaning of the word subjected to folk etymology is not affected, e.g. Gr. *κουμπιούτερ* ‘computer’ (folk etymologized < *κουμπί* ‘button’) instead of *κομπιούτερ* (< Eng. computer) still refers to the concept of “computer” (Fliatouras 2019). These “errors” from an etymological perspective, begin as individual linguistic constructions but, due to the social character of language, can spread within the community, constituting a kind of collective truth (Rundblad – Kronenfeld 2000). For example, the Gr. word *βρώμικος* ‘dirty’ (folk etymologized < Gr. *βρώμα* ‘food’ in the process of decay, hence stenching) appears almost ten times more often in the Google search engine than the historically more “documented” spelling *βρόμικος* < *βρόμα* ‘noise’ < *βρέμω* ‘make noise’, etc. With regard to “correct” and “incorrect” spelling due to folk etymology, indicative is the proposal of Μωυσιάδης and Κατσούδα (2011), who support the retention of the folk-etymologized form, when certain conditions are met, such as a long historical written tradition, e.g. already Ancient Greek *φάλαινα* ‘wale’ (influenced by *φαλός* ‘white’) instead of the original form *φάλλαίνα* (< *φαλλός* ‘penis’), phonetic change, e.g. *καλυμαύχι* ‘monastic hood’ (influenced by *καλύπτω* ‘cover’ + *αύχην* ‘neck’) instead of original *καμηλαύχιον* (< Lat. *camellaucium*), high frequency of use, e.g. *κτίριο* ‘building’ (influenced by *κτίζω* ‘build’) instead of *κτήριο* (< *οίκητήριον*) etc.⁵

Recipients of folk etymology are considered words of low frequency (Rundblad - Kronenfeld 2000). More specifically, loanwords,⁶ compounds and proper names, as well as lettered words, are very often affected when their historical origin is no longer felt or has faded (Anastasiadis-Symeonidis 2003). For example, *στρωματζάδα* ‘bedding on a mattress’ (folk etymologized < *στρώμα* ‘mattress’) but originally < It. *stramazada* ‘group of people lying in one bed’, *μετάλλιο* ‘medal’ (folk etymologized < *μέταλλον*

⁵ Paretymology may only concern the orthographic recording of a word as in *κτίριο* / *κτήριο* ‘building’ (Fliatouras 2017). The different spellings of words should not, of course, be attributed to the phenomenon of paretymology. Words that deviate in writing from their etymological origin, e.g. *παλικάρι* ‘brave man’ (instead of *παλληκάρι* < *πάλληξ* ‘young boy’) or *αγόρι* ‘boy’ (instead of *αγώρι* < *ἄωρος* ‘unripe’), are most often part of the mechanism of orthographic simplification.

⁶ In Filos’ study about the phenomenon of paretymology in Ancient Greek, several loanwords are highlighted that are related to it, e.g. *αἶθριον* ‘yard’ < lat. *atrium* under the influence of *αἶθ-(ω)* ‘to burn’ and the related term *αἶθ-ουσα* ‘room’ (see also the homonymous but different meaning adjective *αἶθριος*, -ον ‘bright’) (Filos 2019: 176).

‘metal’) but originally < It. fem. *medaglia* ‘jewel’, which was considered a neuter plural, etc. (EAM).

Folk etymology can ultimately be seen as a subcategory of the mechanism of analogy, which relies on the relation of similarity between two elements (Rundblad & Kronenfeld 2000, McMahon 1994: 75). As McMahon (1994) notes:

“Analogy is primarily concerned with the link between sound and meaning, which combine to express particular morphemes or meaningful units. The task of analogy is then to maintain this link by keeping sound structure, grammatical structure and semantic structure in line, especially when sound change might have made their relationship opaque” (McMahon 1994: 70).

As a subcategory of analogy, then, folk etymology seeks to interpret unfamiliar linguistic stimuli through the adoption of creative patterns of “rationalization” of their form and meaning in relation to the respective cultural environment (Rundblad & Kronenfeld 2000). An interesting example is the case of Welsh speakers who alter the word *asphalt* (< Lat. *asphaltum* < Ancient Greek *ἄσφαλτον* ‘bitumen’) to *ashfelt*, by association with the familiar verb *felt* ‘to press wool/cotton into a thick piece of cloth,’ due to their highly spread local occupation. This analogical thought was based on the supposed similar pressure with which ash is added in the making of asphalt (ibid. 2000). On the question of whether *meaning* or *phonetic* similarity with another lexical item plays the most important role, opinions differ. Φλιάτουρας (2017), for example, argues that:

“...folk etymology begins with semantic association, since the bases of folk-etymologizing ‘strive’ to be identified semantically with other elements...” (Φλιάτουρας 2017: 39).

In contrast, Μωυσιάδης and Κατσούδα (2011) (see also Michel 2015) maintain that:

“...The semantic relation plays a reinforcing or secondary role and is not always necessary. For example, αγιόκλημα ‘honeysuckle’ (originally αιγόκλημα < αἶγα ‘goat’ + κλήμα ‘vine’) was formed due to phonetic closeness to the adjective ἅγιος ‘saint’ and only subsequently connected semantically with it, thus acquiring the meaning ‘the

saint's vine '..." (Μωυσιάδης and Κατσούδα 2011: 352).

In international and Greek bibliography, the term folk etymology has prevailed, which is, however, misleading, since the mechanism can lead to more scholarly formations because of overcorrection or intervention (s. Béguelin 2002), something that is unrelated to any “folk” influence. More specifically, paretymological approach to a word or phrase from the perspective of the subject who applies it can be distinguished into two categories. The first involves a conscious intervention, often of scholarly origin with a prescriptive character, such as the attempt to etymologize loanwords based on Greek elements (e.g. Gr. *γέφυρα* ‘bridge’ (a pre-Greek loanword) < γῆ ἐπὶ ὕδωρ ‘land on water’) (Φλιάτουρας 2017). In the same category of conscious processes belongs “playful” folk etymology (e.g. *δεηθώμεν* ‘lets pray’ > ΔΕΗ-θώμεν)⁷ (ibid. 2017).

The second category corresponds to the unconscious change that a lexical structure undergoes based on the linguistic intuition of speakers, because of the phenomenon of analogical change (e.g. Gr. *μαζεύω* ‘to gather’ (influenced by Gr. *μαζί* ‘together’) originally < Hell.Gk. *όμαδεύω* ‘to collect’) (Λ.ΙΝΣ). Consequently, the term folk etymology is used as a hypernym to denote both the conscious reanalysis of a word, possibly carried out by a scholar with didactic or prescriptive intentions, and the unconscious folk-etymological association by wider social strata, hence the term “folk etymology” (Fliatouras 2019).

In terms of its realization, there are two main categories of folk etymology:⁸ A) cases in which phonetic and morphological change occurs, e.g. Gr. *αυτόζυμος* ‘self-leavening’ becomes *εφτάζυμος* (folk etymologized < *εφτά* ‘seven’), etc. B) cases in which re-interpretation of the word takes place without changes to its phonetic form (but possibly to its written form), e.g. in the use of Gr. *ενάριθμος* (*εν* + *αριθμός* ‘number’) with the new meaning ‘numerous’, the first element *εν-* is understood with the meaning ‘many’ rather than ‘easy’ to count which is the prototypical one, or Gr. *καμηλό* ‘kind of colour’ [instead of *καμιλό* < Fr. *camelot*] is connected with *καμήλα* ‘camel’,⁹ etc. (Μωυσιάδης and Κατσούδα 2011, Rundblad - Kronenfeld 2000). It is

⁷ ΔΕΗ is the acronym for the largest electric power company in Greece.

⁸ For a thorough study on the typology and types of paretymology see Michel (2015).

⁹ This case could, perhaps, be included in the more general phenomenon of semantic change and specifically in the “shift of meaning” e.g. Old English *silly* ‘happy’ > English ‘stupid’ or Ancient Greek *ἀγαθός* ‘able, good’ > Middle Greek ‘naïve’ (Fromkin et al. 2012: 665). However, while in the previous examples the cause of the change is often difficult to interpret and is linked to sociocultural developments, in the case of paretymology the answer lies in the “incorrect”, from an etymological point

measured that 85% of folk etymologies fall into the first category (Μότσιου 2015).

Analogical connections in folk etymology may also arise through antonymic semantic relations, e.g. eng. *femelle* > *female* (influenced by *male*) (McMahon 1994: 184). The French word *femelle* was borrowed into English in the 12th century and was a diminutive of French *femme* ‘young woman’. Two centuries later, native speakers of English, unfamiliar with the suffix *-elle*, altered the spelling of the word, assuming it related to the word *male*, something that was reinforced by the fact that both words, *femelle* and *male*, appeared in semantic opposition. The existing parallelism with the nouns *mann* ‘man’ and *wim* + *man* ‘woman’ (> woman) may also have played an essential role (Castaño 2014).

As Winer (1992) also notes, an additional distinction of the phenomenon of folk etymology can be made into two taxonomies. One includes complete changes in the form or meaning of a word (e.g. Gr. *συν* - *τριβάνι* ‘fountain’ (based on the preposition *συν* ‘plus’) < Turk. *sadirvan*). The other refers only to a widespread—but etymologically mistaken—interpretation about the origin of a word (e.g. Gr. *μπριζόλα* ‘steak’ < *ἐν πυρὶ ζέει ὅλα* ‘on fire burning all’ instead of < Ven. *brisiola*) (ΕΑΜ).

Factors influencing the likelihood of the phenomenon occurring are primarily sociolinguistic in nature. First, the educational level of speakers and their knowledge of foreign languages act as inhibitory factors, in the sense of sufficient ability to recognize the morphemes that compose a word. Moreover, linguistic contact itself and the increased influx of foreign terms naturally raise the likelihood of folk-etymologizing words. Specifically, Greek dialects, in contact with languages such as Turkish and Italian, display high rates of folk etymology, e.g. Turk. *kovan* ‘beehive’ > Pontic *βουβάνι* ‘beehive’ (influenced by *βουβανίζω* ‘to make a crowd noise’), It. *garboso* ‘lover’ > Corfu *γαμπρόζος* ‘lover’ (influenced by *γαμπρός* ‘fiance’), etc. (Fliatouras 2019).

Especially regarding child language, studies have shown that behind folk etymology lies a creative cognitive mechanism for language acquisition (Μότσιου 2015). Children engage in this practice because of the need to “fit” linguistic input into their already existing experiences, e.g. Gr. *πουλιατζής* (based on *πουλώ* ‘sell’) instead of *παλιατζής* ‘peddler’ (< *παλιός* ‘old’ + *-τζής* (Μότσιου 2015). What is interesting (and

of view, interconnection of morphemes that belong to different word – families.

applies to adults) is that this association of existing linguistic material aims at classifying linguistic data while at the same time facilitating memorization and retrieval of new lexical items. Words are no longer isolated but belong to a semantic network. Generally, for children these strategies are an indication of the attempt to systematize the data of their linguistic experience and play a particularly significant role in language acquisition (Μότσιου 2015).

3 Folk etymology and Latin loans

Regarding Latin loans, the phenomenon of “connecting” Latin words with Greek ones was a frequent practice among lexicographers and grammarians of the late Hellenistic and Byzantine periods. For example, in the Suda Lexicon we find: “Κανδήλα: παρὰ τὸ καίειν δῆλα” [“Candle: from denoting burning”] via analogical attraction. This practice of “imaginative” etymologizing was also attempted with Greek words, e.g. in the *Etymologicum Magnum* we read: “ἄνθρωπος: παρὰ τὸ ἄνω θρεῖν ἥγουν ἄνω βλέπειν· μόνος γάρ τῶν ἄλλων ζώων ὁ ἄνθρωπος ἄνω βλέπει” [“man: from up seeing, meaning looking up, because only man among animals sees/looks up (...)”], due to the absence of methodological principles on which the science of linguistics is based.¹⁰

Moreover, knowing that the authors of these works handled Latin with ease and possibly recognized the characteristic similarity between Lat. *candela* ‘candle’ and Greek *κανδήλα*, one could assume that any attempt to Hellenize the words falls within the framework of the linguistic policy of purism and linguistic purging of that period (s. also Brucker 1988: 62 – 66).

Nevertheless, the documented decline in the level of bilingualism in Byzantium after the 5th–6th century, to the point that it was difficult to find translators of Latin (Horrocks 2010: 197), allows the possibility to presume that this kind of folk-etymological interpretation may also have taken place among lower social strata. For example, in papyrological texts (s. ex. 15) we find the spelling *σταύλος* ‘stable’ (influenced by *αὐλή* ‘yard’) instead of *στάβλος* (< *stabulum*). As will be mentioned later (chapter 4), orthography plays a crucial role in the recognition of written words and

¹⁰ The first written etymological analyses should be sought, already, in Homer (Filos 2019). The Platonic dialogue *Cratylus*, however, is considered the first systematic attempt to examine the issue of the etymological root and meaning of words. The theoretical background of the interpretations attempted there is mainly based on onomatopoeia, which invokes the causal relationship between signifier and signified. However, scientific study has proven categorically that this relationship is purely conventional. Due to the above linguistic inconsistency, the ancient text is full of paronymies.

affects linguistic ability, since it appears to be part of the mental lexicon (Derwing 1992: 196–198). This distinction is crucial for evaluating whether a given folk-etymological association reflects broader linguistic intuition or remains confined to learned, prescriptive discourse.

Through this strategy of reanalyzing loanwords into Greek morphemes and creating semantic transparency, it becomes plausible that the integration, assimilation, and survival of a foreign element is facilitated—especially in cases of monolingual speech communities.¹¹

4 I/E origin and lexical grouping of loans

Beyond the purely folk-etymological cases recorded in written sources, we can assume that the phonetic proximity of Latin words to existing Greek ones, due to their common Indo-European origin, also contributed to the integration of particular loans. This hypothesis is based on the concept of the mental lexicon, that is, the way in which the stock of words is organized as internalized knowledge in the human mind (Ξυδόπουλος 2007: 81). The fact that the mental (stable) lexicon consists of unanalyzable lemmas—stems¹² which form the core of the semantic, associative, and other types of information/knowledge a speaker possesses about words—is of major importance (ibid. 2007: 88–89).

As modern linguistic research has shown, the recognition of written words is achieved through a combination of information derived from both the phonological and the orthographic (mental) lexicon (Μουσιάδης 2011). The initial syllables of words are particularly important, salient and distinctive for the activation of lexical units in the mental lexicon, e.g. the initial segments [kri] in Greek activate the words *κρίση* ‘judgment’, *κρίνω* ‘to judge’, *κρίμα* ‘pity’, but also *Κρήτη* ‘Crete’ (!) (Γαβριηλίδου et al. 2021: 251). Likewise, at the lexical level the word *μήλο* ‘apple’ is phonologically associated with *μύλος* ‘mill’ (ibid. 2021: 251).

¹¹ In the field of Modern Greek Dialects, paronymy appears to be particularly productive and is directly linked to the long-standing linguistic contact with other linguistic communities, e.g. Turk. *yuvarlak* ‘type of food’ > *γιουβαρ(ε)λάκια* (based on *βαρέλι* ‘barrel’), Turk. *bayrak* ‘flag’ > *μπαϊράκι* > Cretan *μπαεράκι* (based on *αεράκι* ‘little wind’), It. *poltrona* ‘armchair’ > (based on *πολύ* ‘much’ + *θρόνα* ‘thone’), It. *caprifoglio* ‘gooseberry’ > Kerk. *καρποφολι* (based on *καρπός* ‘fruit’) etc. (Φλιάτουρας 2017, Fliatouras 2019).

¹² In contrast to the dynamic dictionary, in which the morphological mechanisms of inflection, production and composition are registered (Ξυδόπουλος 2007:89).

In psychometric experiments examining the reception of new words, it has been shown that new words that present phonetic similarity to already known ones are easier to learn. In fact, the greater the number of “phonological neighbors” of a new word, the greater the advantage in lexical acquisition (Stamer and Vitevitch 2012). Consequently, the acoustic similarity (and, to an extent, the semantic similarity), most likely, led to the grouping and organization of Latin loans into lexical networks and subsequently facilitated their integration into the language. Indicative examples include Latin loanwords such as *δομέστικος* ‘official’ (< domesticus), *σκουτάρι* ‘shield’ (< scutum), *άρματα* ‘weapons’ (< arma) etc., where the similarity with other Ancient Greek words of common I/E origin is evident (see Lat. *domus* ~ Gr. *δόμος* ‘house’, Lat. *scutum* ~ Gr. *σκότος* ‘leather’, Lat. *arma* (pl.) ~ Gr. *ἄρμα* ‘chariot’, etc.).

Reborrowed-loans (Rückwanderer), likewise, are more easily associated with the “source word,” due to morphological and sometimes semantic similarity—provided the latter is still in use at the time of borrowing. For example, Hell.Gk. *φασίολος* ‘bean’ (< Lat. *phasiolus* < *phaselus* < *φάσηλος*) is associated with Ancient/Hell.Gk. *φάσηλος* ‘bean’, or Hell.Gk. *κρίκελλος* ‘hoop’ (< Lat. *cricellus* < *κρίκος*) with Ancient Gr. *κρίκος* / Hell.Gk. *κίρκος* ‘hoop’.

The above perspective is based, essentially, on the general cognitive ability of the human mind to recognize patterns and to create analogical relations between them (Rundblad and Kronenfeld 2000).

5 Examples of folk etymology from sources

The mechanisms outlined above provide the analytical framework for the examination of Latin loanwords that follows. Below are all the examples¹³ of Latin loanwords of Standard Modern Greek that are of great interest in terms of paretymology. The words were chosen from a collection of total Latin loans attested in SMG (s. Georgiou 2025). The following entries identify both cases where morphological change has occurred due to the phenomenon of paretymology (e.g. ex. 5) and cases that are exclusively related to an incorrect – etymological – interpretation (e.g. ex. 11). Also, in some examples, where it is noted, paretymology is not explicitly reflected through a lexical analysis carried out in a source of Greek literature but is a position of modern Greek

¹³ Examples are numbered by lexical item. Cited sentences are provided as supporting evidence and are not separately numbered.

dictionaries (e.g. ex. 14):

(1) Hell.Gk./Med.Gk. **βερικόκκιον/βερίκοκκον** ‘apricot’ (SMGk. *βερίκοκο*) (s. ΕΛΜ, Μουσιάδης and Κατσούδα 2011)

The latin loanword was introduced into the language during the Hell.Gk. period (Hell.Gk. *πραικόκ(κ)ιον* < Latin *praecoquum* ‘apricot’. The reinterpretation of the form appears to have been triggered by its phonological proximity to Greek **κόκκος** ‘granule’, which provided a readily accessible lexical anchor. This association can be analysed as a case of folk-etymological reanalysis via analogical attraction, whereby the borrowed item was integrated into the Greek lexicon through alignment with a formally and semantically familiar native element. The spelling with double /kk/ already appears in the original form *πραικόκ(κ)ιον* ‘apricot’:

- a. [...] *ἐστὶ καὶ τὰ πραικόκκια καλούμενα* [...] ‘there are also the so called *πραικόκκια* (apricots)’
Galen, 2nd c. AD, *On the Powers of Foods* (6, 466, 5)
- b. [...] *καὶ βερικόκκια καὶ κεράσια καὶ πάντα τὰ ὅμοια πλὴν συκαμίνων* [...] ‘and apricots and cherries and all the same except for berries’
Artemidorus of Daldis (priest), 2nd c. AD, *Oneirocritica* (1.73.28)

This process took place from the beginning of the attestation of the word in Greek texts (s. Georgiou 2025) suggesting that folk-etymological reinterpretation may have accompanied the early stages of the word’s contributing to its integration into Greek, in addition to supporting its later diachronic survival. In addition, it is possible that it contributed to the phonological form of the word since at that period /kk/ could be pronounced as prolonged /k/ (s. Horrocks 2010).

The repeated attestation of this reinterpretation in medieval and post-medieval non-metalinguistic material suggests that folk etymology functioned here not as an isolated explanatory strategy, but as a mechanism facilitating the continued transmission and retention of the loanword. Importantly, the process appears to have operated primarily at the level of lexical interpretation rather than through substantial phonological reshaping:

- c. [...] τὸ βερίκοκκον ἐνθεματίζεται εἰς δαμασκηνόν [...] ‘apricot is grafted into a plum (tree)’
Geoponica 10th c. AD (10.76.6.2)
-

(2) SMGk. **βίσωνας** ‘bison’

Triggered by formal similarity to the toponym **Βιστωνίς**, the originally latin loan (Hell.Gk. *βίσων* < Lat. *bison*) has written evidence of folk-etymological reanalysis via onomastic attraction, resulting in a reinterpretation of its origin in late antique Greek sources:

[...] ὅτι ἐστὶ βοῦς βίσων καλούμενος, ὃς ἔχει τὴν γλῶσσαν ὡς σαρκοφάγον. ἔστι δὲ ἀπὸ Βιστωνίδος γῆς.

‘this is an ox that is called bison that has a carnivore-like tongue. It actually comes from Βιστωνίδα land’

Timotheus of Gaza, 6th c. AD, *On Animals* (28,16)

(3) SMGk. **διαφεντεύω** ‘to rule’ (s. Κριαράς Dic., ΕΛΜ)

Triggered by formal and semantic proximity to Hell.Gk. **αὐθέντης** ‘ruler’, the originally Latin loan **δηφενδεύω** (< *defendo*), firstly attested with the meaning ‘to protect’ (s. 3a), underwent **folk-etymological reanalysis via analogical attraction**, resulting in a **semantic shift towards** ‘to rule’ (s. 3b) and the later stabilization of the form **διαφεντεύω** in Medieval and Modern Greek:

- a. [...] Ἡ Τροία τέφρα γίνεται, οὐδεὶς τὴν διαφεντεύει [...]

‘Troy becomes ashes, no one protects it’

The War of Troy, 13th c. AD (1696)

- b. [...] ὁποῖον (το νησίν) ἐδιαυθέντευεν ὁ ρηξ τῆς Εγγλιτέρας [...]

‘the island that the king of England ruled’

Emmanuel Lomenitis (Georgilas), *Historical explanation about Belisarius* (237) (Med.Gk.) in Κριαράς Dic.

(4) (SMGk. **ερμάρι(ο)/αρμάρι(ο)** ‘drawer, closet’

The Hell.Gk. loan **ἀρμάριον** ‘closet’ (< Lat. *armarium* ‘armory, chest’) due to its formal similarity with the Greek noun **ἐρμάριον** (‘small statue’ < **Ἑρμής**), has written evidence of **conscious folk-etymological reinterpretation in learned lexicographical tradition**, resulting in a **reanalysis of its origin and semantic motivation** (4a). This reinterpretation attests in non-metalinguistic contexts, where **ἐρμάριον** is used with the everyday meaning ‘closet’, indicating a possible diffusion into actual usage (4b):

a. *Ἀρμάριον: Ὅτι τὰ λεγόμενα παρ' ἡμῖν ἀρμάρια, «ἐρμάρια» ὀφείλουσι λέγεσθαι... Οἱ γὰρ Ἕλληνες οἷα τινὰς ἀνδριάντας ἐποίουν, μήτε χεῖρας μήτε πόδας ἔχοντας· τούτους δὲ Ἑρμᾶς ἐκάλουν· οὗ ὑποκοριστικὸν, ἐρμάριον. Εποιοῦν δὲ αὐτοὺς διάκενους, θύρας ἔχοντας καθάπερ τοιχοπυργίσκους [...]*

‘*Ἀρμάριον*: The so called to us *ἀρμάρια*, «*ἐρμάρια*» should be called ... Because Greeks made some of these statues without hands and legs, and they called them *Hermas*, of which the diminutive is *hermarion*. They also made those hollow inside with doors like wall-towers’

Etymologicum Magnum 12th c. AD

b. *ὅτι τῶν βρωμάτων τῶν ἀπολειφθέντων ἀπὸ τῶν ἀγγείων πολλάκις ἀμνημόνησεν ἐν τῷ ἐρμαρίῳ*

‘that he has frequently forgotten the leftover food from the pots in the closet’

Dositheos II, Patriarch of Jerusalem, 17th c. AD, *Dodekabiblos Dositheou* (IA'—II' 11.56.30)

(5) Med.Gk./SMGk. **καλημαύχι(ον)/καλυμμαύκι(ον)** ‘religious hat’

Triggered by formal similarity between the medieval loan **καμηλαύχιον** (< Lat. *camellacium*) and the Greek elements **κάλυμμα** ‘cover’ and **αὐχὴν** ‘neck’, the word is recorded undergoing **conscious folk-etymological reinterpretation in learned sources** (5a), resulting in a **transparent compound analysis** (‘covering of the neck’). This reinterpretation was subsequently diffused into non-metalinguistic medieval usage (5b), as reflected in later attestations:

- a. [...] κυρίως καλυμαύκιον λέγεται ἀπὸ τοῦ καλύπτειν τὸν ἀνχένα.
‘it is mainly called καλυμαύκιον from covering the neck’

Pseudo-Zonaras, 13th c. AD, *Lexicon*

- b. καλυμαύχιον βροχῆς

‘hat for the rain’

Scholia in Aristophanem: scholia in nubes (scholia anonyma recentiora)
(268b,1) (Med.Gk.)

(6) SMGk. **καντήλι** ‘vigil lamb’

Triggered by formal and semantic proximity to **καίειν** ‘burning’ and **δῆλος** ‘visible’, the Hell.Gk. loan **κανδήλα** (< Lat. *candela*) underwent **conscious folk-etymological reinterpretation in learned lexicographical tradition**, resulting in a **transparent semantic motivation** (‘that which burns visibly’):

Κανδήλα: παρὰ τὸ καίειν δῆλα.

‘Κανδήλα: from showing that it burns’

Suda Lexicon, 10th c. AD

(7) SMGk. **κλεισούρα** ‘frowsty, passage’

Triggered by formal and semantic proximity to the Greek verb **κλείω** ‘close’, the term **κλεισούρα** (< *clausura*, possibly reinforced through loan-translation) underwent **folk-etymological reinterpretation**, resulting in its integration as a transparent formation denoting ‘closed passages’, as reflected both in historical narrative usage and in later learned etymological speculation (7b):

- a. [...] καὶ ἔκλεισε τὰς κλεισούρας καὶ τὰ διαβατὰ, ποῦ μὲν με τείχους, ποῦ δὲ με νευραίας καὶ ζύλα [...]

‘and he closed the passages and the alleys with walls and ropes and logs’

George the Monk, 9th c. AD, *Short Chronicle* (110, 1216, 42)

b. *Κλεισούραι, αι, Suid. q.d. Clausurae: sed κλεισούραι videtur e κλείω [...]*

In Henri Estienne (16th c.) we find association with the verb *κλείω* (in Du Cange Dictionary)

(8) SMGk. **κάψα** ‘container’ (different from *κάψα* ‘heat’ < *καίω*)

Triggered by formal similarity to the Greek verb **κάπτω** (‘to contain’), the Latin loan **κάψα** (< Lat. *capsa*) is captured undergoing a **conscious folk-etymological reinterpretation in learned lexicographical tradition** (8b), resulting in a **transparent semantic motivation** for the meaning ‘container’, clearly distinguished from the homonymous **κάψα** ‘heat’:

a. *Κάψα: κίστη ἢ θήκη*

‘Κάψα: cist or case’

Photius, 9th c. AD, Lexicon

b. *Κάψα, παρὰ τὸ κάπτω ῥήμα, τὸ δηλοῦν τὸ χωρῶ, γέγονεν, ἡ χωρητικὴ οὗσα τῶν ἐντιθεμένων ἐν αὐτῇ [...]*

‘Κάψα, from the verb *κάπτω*, meaning to fit, that further became the place on which to put something’

Etymologicum Magnum 12th c. AD

(9) SMGk. **λανάρι** ‘carder’ (< Hell.Gk. *λανάριος* ‘wool worker’)

Triggered by formal and semantic proximity to the Greek noun **λῆνος** (‘sheep’s wool’), the Latin loan **λανάριος** (< *lanarius*, *lana* ‘wool’) underwent **folk-etymological reinterpretation**, resulting in the coexistence of the variants **λανάριος** and **ληνάριος** (e.g. *Scholia in Clementem* A 781 B) and reinforcing the word’s semantic transparency in Greek usage:

βεβρίθει λήνεσσιν: τοῖς ἐρίοις, ὅθεν καὶ λανάριοι καλοῦνται οἱ κτενισταί.

‘heavy from λήνεσσιν (λῆνος ‘wool’): from wool, thus the woolworkers are called λανάριοι’

Scholia on Apollonius Rhodius (270, 1) (Med.Gk.)

(10) SMGk. **λαρδί** ‘pork fat’ (< dim. of Hell.Gk. *λάρδος*)

Triggered by formal and semantic proximity to Hell.Gk. Greek adjective **λαρινός** (‘fatty’), the Latin loan **λάρδος** (< Lat. *lardum* ‘pork fat’) and its diminutive **λαρδί(ον)** underwent **folk-etymological reinterpretation**, resulting in reinforced semantic transparency through association with an inherited Greek descriptor of fatness:

Λαρινὸν τὸ λιπαρόν, ἐξ οὗ καὶ λάρδος

‘*Λαρινὸν* the fatty, thus *λάρδος*’

Laurentius Lydus 6th c. AD, *On the Months* (4, 91, 5)

(11) **μάγουλο** ‘cheek’

Triggered by formal and semantic association with **μάλα** ‘much’ and **οὔλον** ‘gum’, the Latin loan **μάγουλον** (< Lat. *magulum* ‘jaw’) underwent **conscious folk-etymological reinterpretation in a medical text** of 8th century, showing a transparent compound analysis referring to the cheek and gums:

Τὰ δὲ μάγουλα καὶ μῆλα λέγονται [...] παρὰ τὸ μάλα καὶ τὸ οὔλον [...]

‘The *μάγουλα* (‘cheeks’) are also called apples [...] from *μάλα* (‘much’) and *οὔλον* (‘gum’)’

Meletius (physician, 8th c. AD), *On Human Nature* (74,4)

(12) SMGk. **μαντή/ίλι** ‘handkerchief’ (< Hell.Gk. *μανδήλιον*)

Triggered by possibly formal similarity to **μανδύας** ‘mantle’ (cf. *μανδύλιον* ‘monk’s cloak’) on the one hand (s. Georgiou 2025 and 12a), and by reinterpretation as a transparent compound from **μάσσειν** ‘to clean’ and **ῥλη** ‘matter’ on the other, the Latin loan **μανδήλιον** (< Lat. *mantilium* ‘handkerchief’) underwent **conscious folk-etymological reinterpretation** in learned lexicographical tradition (12b), resulting in competing analyses and in the coexistence of variant spellings (*μαντήλιον* / *μανδύλιον*) in Greek usage. In TLG (2025) there are 148 occurrences with /η/, 51 with /υ/:

- a. *Καὶ λοιπὸν ἀποτιθέμενος τότε σάβανον καὶ μανδύλιν, καὶ πᾶσαν τὴν ἀρχιερατικὴν στολὴν [...]*

‘And so abandoning the shroud and the cloak and all the high priest suit’

Officia ecclesiastica, Euchologion 42.4.13 in Lampe Dic.

- b. *Χειρόμακτρον: ὃ παρὰ Ῥωμαίοις καλεῖται μανδήλιον. Παρὰ τὸ μάπτειν τὴν ὕλην.*

‘Handkerchief: the so called μανδήλιον by Romans. From cleaning the matter.’

Suda Lexicon, 10th c. AD

(13) SMGk. **μαρούλι** ‘lettuce’

Triggered by formal similarity to **Μαϊούλιον** (s. Meyer 1895) and by associative reinterpretation involving the verb **μαραίνω** (s. EAM), the loanword **μαρούλιον** (< Lat. *amarulus* ‘bitter’) underwent **folk-etymological reinterpretation**, resulting in reanalyses of its origin without affecting its basic lexical meaning:

Θριδακίνη: τὸ παρ’ ἡμῖν μαϊούλιον. Λέγεται καὶ θρίδαζ.

‘Lettuce: the familiar μαϊούλιον. It is also called θρίδαζ.’

Suda Lexicon, 10th c. AD

(14) SMGk. **μνημούρι** ‘grave’ (< Hell.Gk. *μεμόριον*)

Triggered by formal and semantic proximity to greek **μνήμα** ‘grave’, the inherited form **μεμόριον** (< Lat. *memorium* ‘grave’) according to temporary dictionaries of Greek underwent **folk-etymological reinterpretation** (s. Λ.ΙΝΣ, EAM), resulting in the later form **μνημούρι**, as reflected in medieval vernacular usage. While this development is commonly attributed to folk etymology in the lexicographical tradition, a contribution from **calquing** cannot be excluded:

Early forms:

- a. [...] *τοὺς ἐν μεμορίοις οἰκοῦντας* [...]

‘the residents of the tombs’

Fourth Ecumenical Council, 451 AD, Council of Chalcedon (2, 1, 2, 115, 9)

Medieval:

- b. [...] νὰ πάμε στὸ μνημόρι τῆς κεράς μου [...]
'let's go to the tomb of my lady'
Voskopoula 411

(15) SMGk. **ξί/υγκι** 'fat' (< Hell.Gk. οξύγγιον 'fat')

The development of **οξύγγιον** (< Lat. *axungia* 'fat') into later forms **ξύγγι** / **ξύγκι** has been associated with formal similarity to **ὀξύς** 'acute' (s. EAM, Triandaphyllidis 1909: 107), suggesting **folk-etymological reinterpretation** in some lexicographical accounts. However, the spelling with <υ> may alternatively reflect **phonetic rendering of the Latin source**, rather than a genuine folk-etymological association (cf. Hell.Gk. pronunciation of υ as /y:/ and the form ὀξούγγιον in Trapp Dictionary):

Original form:

- a. [...] ὅλη δὲ κοπεῖσα μετὰ ἀξουγγίας παλαιᾶς τὰ παλαιὰ τῶν ἐλκῶν καὶ
δυσασπούλωτα θεραπεύει [...]
'all cutted with old fat it cures the previous incurable ulcer'
Crateuas, 1st c. AD, *Fragmenta* (3, 5)

Also in papyri with /υ/ (likely phonetic rendering):

- b. [...] παρέσχεν ἀν- τὴ τοῦ ὀξυγγείου () κολλουρίων ὑδρείαν () [...]
'he provided instead of fat, collyrium of water' (?)
P.Oxy 59 4001, 5th c. AD

Later:

- c. [...] πεντακοσίους καβούρους ὅλους βαρβάτους, κουνουπίων ξύγγιν λίτρας ρ' [...]
'five hundred strong crabs, mosquito fat 100 liters'
Spanos (parody of ecclesiastical texts), 14th/15th c. AD (1698)
-

(16) SMGk. **πεταλίδα** ‘limpet’

Triggered by formal and semantic proximity to (‘petal, plate-like shape’), the Hell.Gk. loan **πατέλλιον** (< Lat. *patella* ‘dish, plate’) underwent **folk-etymological reinterpretation** (s. EAM, IANE), resulting in the later form **πεταλίδα** and in a transparent motivation based on perceived shape similarity:

Original forms:

- a. [...] ,οἴνου παλαιοῦ τὸ ἱκανόν, εἰς πατέλλιον βαλὼν καὶ ἐψήσας. [...]
‘old wine able to put in a plate and hit/bake’
Hippiatrica (compilation), 5th/6th c. AD (26, 36, 2)

Later:

- b. [...] πεταλίδες τε ὁμοῦ μὲ τοὺς κοχλίου, στρείδια, μύδια, κτένια, ὠραίας ἀχηβάδες
[...]
‘limpets, together with snails, oysters, mussels, scallops, beautiful clams’
Alexander and Semiramis, 14th/15th c. AD, Anonymous Narrative, B 53.1107

(17) SMGk. **σταῦλος** ‘stable’

Triggered by formal and semantic proximity to **αὐλή** ‘yard’, the Latin loan **σταῦλος** (< *stabulum*) has been associated with **folk-etymological reinterpretation** (s. EAM), potentially contributing to the coexistence of the spellings **σταῦλος** / **στάβλος** in Greek usage. At the same time, this variation may reflect **phonological convergence**, rather than a fully developed folk-etymological process. In TLG: spelling with /β/ has 225 occurrences, with /υ/ 187 occurrences. It is again possible that phonological convergence of the two spellings coincides with folk-etymological association:

- a. *καρνοστάσιον· στάβλος, ὅπου τὸ κάρνιον ἴσταται
‘καρνοστάσιον’ stable, where the cart (?) is’
Hesychius, 5th c. AD, *Lexicon*

- b. [...] καὶ παρέλαβε τὸν σταῦλον τοῦ Πρασίνου μέρους λιπόμενον, καὶ ἐνίκησε κατὰκράτος.

‘and he received the ‘stable of race horses’ of the Green team while losing, and crashed the opponents’

Ioannes Malalas, 5th/6th c. AD, *Chronographia* (16,6,5)

In papyri:

- c. [...] εἰ δὲ ἐστὶν σταῦλον εἰς κλίσιν ἐν αὐτῷ ἄλογα [...]

‘if there is a stable where horses rest’

p.rain.unterricht 109r., 6th c. AD

(18) SMGk. **τούφα** ‘strand’

Triggered by formal similarity to Gr. **τύφος** ‘arrogance’, the Latin loan **τούφα** (< Lat. *tufa* ‘helmet mane’) underwent **conscious folk-etymological reinterpretation in learned historiographical tradition**, resulting in a semantic reanalysis motivated by the notion of ‘arrogance’ associated with wearing an upright head ornament:

[...], *τίαρα ταινιωθεὶς ὀρθία* (“set upright on the head”) ἦν τοῦφαν καλεῖ ὁ δημῳδὴς καὶ πολλὸς ἄνθρωπος, *τύφον* (“arrogance”), *οἶμαι, ὠνομασμένην, ὡς τετυφῶσθαι* “to be puffed up” ’) *ποιοῦσαν τοὺς ταύτη ἀναδουμένους* [...] ‘tiara set upright on his head*, that is *τοῦφα* called by most people, from *τύφον* (‘arrogance’) I think it is named, because it makes puffed up the one that wears it’ *(referring to Prusias, Bulgarian ruler)

Ioannes Zonaras, 12th c. AD, *Epitome of Histories* (566,16)

The cases examined in this study show that folk etymology constituted a persistent and productive mechanism in the diachronic integration of Latin loanwords into Greek. Far from being an occasional or marginal phenomenon, folk-etymological reinterpretation operated at different levels—formal, semantic, and orthographic—both in unconscious vernacular usage and in conscious learned traditions. In many instances, it seems to have enhanced the transparency of originally opaque loanwords, facilitated their semantic accessibility, and reinforced their stability across historical stages of Greek. Even where alternative explanations such as phonological convergence or

calquing cannot be excluded, the repeated activation of folk-etymological associations demonstrates its role as a mediating force between inherited Greek structures and borrowed lexical material. Taken together, the evidence suggests that folk etymology contributed not only to the reinterpretation but also to the long-term survival and integration of certain Latin loans within the Greek lexicon.

6 Examples of folk etymological association with paronymous Greek words due to I/E kinship

A group of Latin loanwords introduced into Greek display formal similarity to pre-existing Greek lexemes, many of which are etymologically related through common Indo-European origin. In such cases, inherited Greek lexemes of common Indo-European origin (s. words inside brackets bellow) may have functioned as cognitive anchors (s. chapter 4), enabling speakers to interpret the incoming Latin forms as structurally and semantically familiar:

άρμα ‘weapon’ < Lat. *arma* (~ *ἄρμα* ‘war chariot’), *δομέστικος* ‘official’ < Lat. *domesticus* (~ *δόμος* ‘house’), *καρίνα* ‘keel’ < Lat. *carina* (~ *κάρυον* ‘nut’ – metaphorical), *κούπα* ‘cup’ < Lat. *cupa* (~ *κύπελλον* ‘cup’), *μουλάρι(ον)* < Hell.Gk. *μούλα* ‘mule’ < Lat. *mula* (~ *μύχλος* ‘stallion, ass’), *μούσκλη(ον)* ‘moss’ < Lat. *muscum* (~ *μόσχος* ‘sprout’), *νονός* ‘godfather’ < *nonnus* (~ *νέννος* ‘uncle, grandfather’), *πακτώνω* ‘to rent’ < ελνστ. *πάκτον* < Lat. *pactum* ‘agreement’ (~ *πακτόω* ‘to make firm’), *πανί(ον)* ‘cloth’ < ελνστ. *πάννος* < Lat. *pannus* ‘piece of cloth’ (~ *πηνίον* ‘weaving thread’), *πουκάμισο* ‘shirt’ < ελνστ. *ὑποκάμισον* < Lat. *camisia* (~ *καμάσιον* ‘blouse’), *πουλί(ον)* ‘bird’ < Lat. *pullus* (~ *πῶλος* ‘young animal’), *σέλ(λ)α* ‘saddle’ < Lat. *sella* (~ *έλλά* ‘seat’), *σκουτάρι(ον)* ‘shield’ < Lat. *scutum* (~ *σκούτος* ‘hide of shields’), *φακιόλι(ον)* ‘headband’ < Lat. *faciale* (~ *φάκελος* ‘bandage’).

In order to support the argument that morphologically related Greek words, due to a common I/E origin, facilitated the introduction of certain Latin loans into Greek, it is important that these similar “native” words were in use during the period of the emergence of the Latin words respectively. A few examples of this hypothesis with further elaboration follow:

(19) Hell.Gk. *δομέστικος* ‘domestic, official’ (< Lat. *domesticus*)

Triggered by formal and semantic proximity to the inherited Ancient/Hell.Gk./Med.Gk. noun **δόμος** ‘house’(s. L&S), the Latin loan **δομέστικός** (< *domesticus*) could be readily interpreted as ‘belonging to the household’, allowing its early integration through **folk-etymological association** facilitated by shared Indo-European morphology (IE root *dema– ‘to build’):

The meaning ‘domestic’ dates back to the 5th c. AD:

οἶνον δομε<σ>τικὸν λαγύνιον

‘homemade wine in a jug’

Sammelbuch griechischer Urkunden aus Aegypten 15255 in DGE.

(20) Hell.Gk. **νονός** ‘uncle’ (< Lat. *nonnus*)

The borrowing of **νονός** (< *nonnus*) may have been facilitated by its close resemblance to the pre-existing Hell.Gk. Greek kinship term **νέννος** ‘uncle, grandfather’ (cf. Hesychius Lexicon), whose nursery-word origin and semantic overlap provided a natural **lexical anchor** for the interpretation of the loan.

(21) Hell.Gk. **πακτ(ῶ) -ώνω** ‘to rent’

The formation of **πακτώνω** (< Hell.Gk. *πάκτον* (< *pactum*) was facilitated by its association with the Hell.Gk. Greek verb **πακτόω** ‘to make firm’ (cf. Automedon (AP 10,23 c.a.), 1st c. AD) (IE root *peh₂k- ‘to fix, make firm’), allowing the borrowed form to be reanalysed within an existing verbal pattern through **morphological alignment**.

7 Observations

It should be emphasized that regarding the tendency of lexicographers and scholars to folk-etymologize, there is often the interpretative risk that the connection made with Greek words may have not been carried out by most speakers but restricted solely to a lettered linguistic level. This practice was motivated, as mentioned above, by the predetermined linguistic stance of scholars to attribute the necessary “Greekness” to as

many foreign words as possible.¹⁴ In this sense, the etymologizing of the word *μοῦστος* ‘must’ e.g. in relation to the word *μύστης* ‘mysterious’ by Io. Laurentius may reflect a lexical analysis that it is very doubtful whether it echoed more popular linguistic layers:

(22) Ὅτι μοῦστον τὸν οἶνον οἱ Ῥωμαῖοι ἔγνωσαν καλεῖν ὡσανεὶ μύστην, ὅτι μυστήριον πρῶτοι Σαρδιανοὶ προσηγόρευσαν.

‘That the wine *μοῦστον* Romans called like *μύστην* (‘secret’), because Sardinians first mystery called it’

Ioannes Laurentius Lydus (official, historian), 6th c. AD, *On the Months* (1, 4, 1)

Furthermore, folk-etymological interpretations in words such as *δηνάριον* ‘dinar’ (~ *δεινά* ‘bad’ + *αἶρει* ‘cancel’) or *δικτάτωρ* ‘dictator’ (~ *δις* ‘twice’) are probably of little significance for their integration and survival, due to the widespread use of such cultural loans anyway, like coins or political titles:

(23) Δηνάριον· νόμισμα τί ἐστὶ δηνάριον, ὅτι τὰ δεινὰ αἶρει παρεχόμενον.

‘Dinar· a kind of coin is a dinar, from giving relief to bad things’

Etymologicum Gudianum 11th c. A.D.

(24) Δικτάτωρ: ὁ διπλασίαν τὴν ἀρχὴν ἔχων. ὅς παρὰ Ῥωμαίοις δισύπατος καλεῖται, ἀρχὴ δ’ ἦν πρόσκαιρος, οὐ διὰ βίου, καὶ ἀνέυθυνος. ἢ ὁ μονάρχης πάντων κρατῶν.

‘Dictator: the twice the power having, that by Romans dishypatos is called, his power is temporary, not for life and irresposible. Or the ruler of states.’

Suda Lexicon, 10th c. AD

¹⁴ The difficulty of ascertaining the adoption of a paratymologized form by most speakers is also found in antiquity, where many lexical analyses are likely to reflect the individual views of grammarians, poets, rhetoricians, etc. For instance, in the Platonic *Cratylus*: : (...Ὁρέστης: τὸ θηριῶδες ‘ferocious’... ἄγριον ‘wild’... καὶ τὸ ὄρεινόν ‘mountainous’ ἐνδεικνύμενος ‘showing’ [394e]), the mentioned etymology may serve the plot of the philosophical dialogue or other theoretical parameters of the literary work (Filos 2019).

In addition, the number of words above (~10%), compared to the total list of latin loanwords (s. Georgiou 2025), shows that folk etymology was probably not a decisive factor for the introduction of Latin loans, without its role being entirely negligible. After all, folk etymology constitutes a functional process, and therefore useful to the language, since it operates as a mechanism of phonological, morphological, and semantic adaptation of loans, whereby the form becomes identical with a morpheme of the lexicon and acquires internal structure (s. Αναστασιάδη Συμεωνίδη 1994: 55, 109). At the same time, it is also a pragmatic mechanism that seeks to integrate a concept/object into the culture of a speech community (Φλιάτουρας 2017). Finally, something not pointed out in the international and Greek bibliography regarding the linguistic phenomenon of folk etymology, and which perhaps deserves further research, is its possible connection with the so-called Principle of Least Effort, in the sense of minimizing the effort/energy expended by a speaker to understand a new word through its association with other already known words (see also Zipf's law, etc.).¹⁵ After all, lexical economy is also the basis, among other things, for the phenomenon of *polysemy*, according to Lehrer (1990: 370), whereby new concepts find semantic expression in existing lexical forms. As she argues, the semantic vagueness of word boundaries, reinforced by the principle of least effort, leads to the use of a ready-made form instead of one newly created from scratch.¹⁶

¹⁵ The basic premise of this principle (first formulated in 1894 by the philosopher G. Ferrero) is based on the fact that a fundamental characteristic of human nature is the search for the greatest result with the least possible effort. Zipf's analysis half a century later suggests that useful behaviors are performed more frequently and over time become easier and shorter to perform. The law that took his name concerns the distribution of various types of data from the natural sciences and humanities, for example, we have few but large cities and many but small ones. Zipf also dealt with the frequency of occurrence of words within a text. Specifically, if words are arranged in descending order of their number of occurrences, then the position/order of a word in this list when multiplied by its frequency of occurrence is equal to a constant. The equation for this relationship is: $r \times f = k$ where r is the position/order of the word, f is the frequency, and k is the constant (Yueying Zhu et al. 2018).

¹⁶ Other linguistic phenomena, such as the omission in Greek of the definite article in phrases such as *μένω σπίτι* 'I stay at home' (vs. *μένω στο σπίτι*), have been argued to be interpreted because of the Principle of Least Effort (Valioli & Psaltou – Joyce 1995: 292, 302).

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